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2026 Global Sports Industry Outlook

AI is reshaping operations, capital is scaling ownership, sports are converging with media and entertainment, and venues are evolving into year-round platforms

Moving into 2026, the global sports industry is evolving and the lens through which it may be viewed is widening. The industry—inclusive of leagues, teams, federations, mega-events, media partners, investors, and more—is entering an age of expansion and transformation. Artificial intelligence is becoming foundational for growth and is emerging as an intelligence layer that strengthens organizations from within and links siloed parts of the business together. Capital continues to flow into the industry, pushing ownership models and operating structures to evolve and elevate. Global ownership groups are extending their reach and influence and blurring the boundaries between sports entities, media, and commerce. And the physical spaces of sports are evolving, too: Stadiums are transforming into year-round entertainment districts that help drive economic value and community resilience far beyond game day.

Across the global sports landscape, growth is visible on every front. The value of media rights continues to climb worldwide,¹ commercial revenues in women's sports are growing at double-digit rates,² numerous stadiums and sports districts are under development across the map,³ and franchise valuations across major leagues continue to reach new highs.⁴ The big question is no longer: "What is the ceiling for the sports industry?" It has become: "How much bigger will the room get?"

In 2026, sports may not only be growing, but increasingly emerging as a frontier of entertainment, culture, and everyday life.



AI enables reimagination of how sports organizations operate and scale

AI has outgrown its role as a trick play. For many sports organizations, it's becoming a whole new game plan. AI may serve as the connective engine that strengthens organizations from within, breaking down data silos, transforming work, and enabling the sports industry to interconnect and grow. Moving into 2026 and beyond, sports organizations looking to compete shouldn't ignore AI. The leaders in the global sports industry may be those who embed AI systems and workflows into applicable aspects of their businesses.

The next wave of AI adoption for sports organizations of all sizes is likely to start in the back office and may quietly impact parts of the business fans rarely see.⁵ AI may augment traditionally repetitive and time-consuming tasks, like automating entries and reconciliations in finance and automating outreach for season ticket renewals with all of the corresponding processing handled seamlessly.⁶ Effective AI implementation—which involves redesigning operating models and thinking intentionally about how humans and AI work together⁷—may free up capacity for the workforce to focus on delivering more strategic and creative work, fit for primetime.

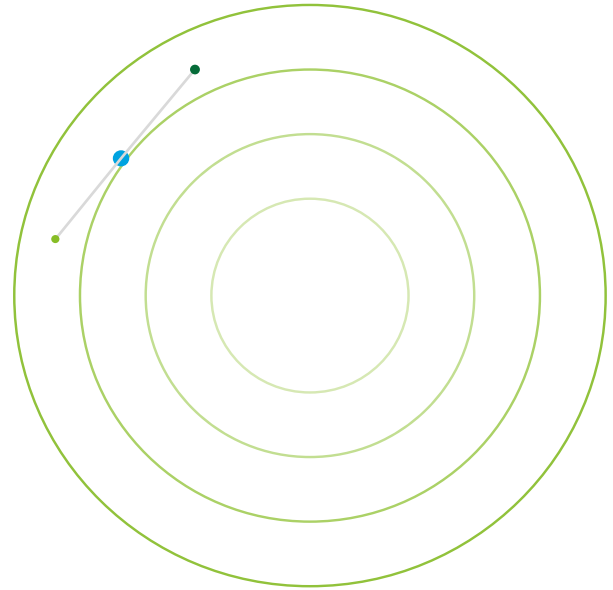
Quicker and more informed decisions may ultimately improve fan experiences and impact sports organizations' success on and off the field of play. AI can be used to bring fans closer to the sports and teams they love: Think real-time analytics in live broadcasts, personalized and AI-generated highlight reels, near immediate responses to fan questions, and improved accessibility and safety inside stadiums.⁸ AI could also be deployed to protect and optimize sports organizations' most valuable assets—their players—by assessing player fitness and conditioning, predicting and preventing injuries, and using AI agents to review game film.⁹ Much of this is already happening at the highest

levels of sport but it may be democratized across organizations given the ubiquity of AI.

All of this is just the beginning of a future that could unfold in short order. AI may allow teams to game plan through scrimmages with digital twin opponents, enable AI agents to handle ticketing and microtransactions automatically, and model and predict crowd patterns across entire stadium districts. Most sports organizations aren't there yet but now may be the time to work on the fundamentals: consolidating and organizing data, building strong internal capabilities, redesigning work, establishing a culture of continuous learning, and developing clear data governance, security, and trust guardrails. The organizations that do this now may shape the industry's next phase of rapid growth.

Strategic questions to consider:

1. -How can your organization effectively redesign work and roles so AI augments human judgment, creativity, and decision-making, rather than simply automating tasks?
2. - Is your data ready for AI? Are critical datasets consolidated, governed, and trusted enough to support enterprisewide use cases?
3. - How is your organization fostering a culture of learning and experimentation that gives employees the time and support to build AI skills?
4. - Where can AI create value in your operations today, and what capabilities and partnerships will you need to scale that value across the enterprise tomorrow?



New investment models reshape sports organizations



As popularity and valuations increase, sports are no longer a passion project or a hobby for wealthy individuals, but a serious business.¹⁰ Private and institutional capital have been flowing into the sports industry for years—across all major US leagues, European football leagues, rugby, cricket, motorsports, and more,¹¹ and increasingly shaping expectations across the broader sports ecosystem, including parts of US college athletics



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